Validation Hierarchy of Evidence

Updated: 2026-10-30.

Stop guessing. Start proving.

The Pyramid

Not all evidence is equal. The course uses one hierarchy, the pyramid every module shows. You start at the bottom and climb. Everything below a payment is *signal*, and signal only earns you the right to run the next, more expensive test (Glossary). Your own opinion is not on the pyramid at all.

Phase	Rung	What it is	What it can show
Problem space	1. Anecdotal evidence	Stories you heard, your own experience	That a problem might exist
Problem space	2. Qualitative interviews	Conversations about past behaviour and spend, with verbatim quotes	That named people have the problem and what it costs them
Problem space	3. Quantitative evidence	A survey that tests what your interviews suggested, or a landing page that counts what people do	How many people in your segment act on it
Solution space	4. Wireframe mockup	A clickable mock that people try	Whether they get the solution and want it
Solution space	5. Functional prototype	A slice of the product that works	Whether it solves the problem
Solution space	6. Paid prototype	Somebody pays for it	Validation. A wallet opened
Growth phase	7 to 9. Growing early product, net positive growth, positive margins	Customers pay repeatedly and the business grows	That it works as a business
Top	Sustainable business, efficient market		

When a survey counts. A survey earns rung 3 only when it tests what your interviews suggested, with closed questions about past behaviour. A survey about the future or about your solution counts as opinion, however many people answer it.

The Rule

Climb. Each test earns the right to run the next one.

If you leave Module 04 still without quantitative evidence, something is wrong. Either the problem isn’t real, or you’re avoiding the scary experiments.

For Each Rung: What to Do

Rung	Experiment	Where the course runs it
2	Problem conversations about the last time it happened (Mom Test)	Modules 00 to 03
3	A landing page with a pass or fail line written before the first visitor, or a survey that tests your interview hypotheses	Module 04
4	A click dummy that people from your segment try	Module 05
5	A prototype built with AI	Module 06
6	A concierge offer or a paid pilot	Modules 08 and 09
7	Paying customers who stay and pay again, counted from your product's records, with a retention line written before you look	Modules 10 and 11

The Kill Question

At each level, ask: **"What would make me abandon this idea?"**

Write it down BEFORE you run the experiment. This prevents motivated reasoning — the #1 killer of student startups. You'll unconsciously interpret ambiguous data as positive unless you've pre-committed to your kill criteria.

Example:

> "If fewer than 3 out of 10 interviewees describe this problem unprompted, the problem isn't painful enough. I'll pivot."

Common Traps

The Survey Trap: A survey of 200 people about what they *would* do feels rigorous but is still opinion. It teaches less than 5 real conversations. Run a survey only to count what your interviews already suggested, with closed questions about what people did.

The Pilot Trap: Building a "small" pilot that takes 6 weeks. If you can't test the core assumption in under 1 week, you're testing the wrong thing.

The Friendly Data Trap: Your friends, classmates, and professors are not your customers. Their enthusiasm means nothing. Talk to strangers who match your ICP.

The Feature Trap: "Users said they want feature X" is opinion dressed up as an interview. What they DO matters. What they SAY they want doesn't.